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Investigating persons

Extension of the mental test model

American psychologists, as we noted in chapter 7, had set about redefining the psychological problem of individual differences in terms of a comparison of performances against a competitively defined standard. This redefinition appeared to be perfectly adapted to the administrative requirements of social institutions whose efficient functioning depended upon some kind of selection process that was rationally defensible. The kinds of tasks that best lent themselves to the measurement of individual differences in this sense were tasks with answers that were unambiguously right or wrong. Performance on such tasks could be readily arithmetized by counting right and wrong answers, a procedure that had long been conventionalized in the institution of school examinations. Improvements in the precision of such procedures, made possible by Galton's fundamental contributions, eventually led to the construction of normed intelligence tests.

It is hardly a cause for surprise that educational institutions provided the setting in which intelligence tests proved themselves best adapted to administrative requirements. Transferred outside their home ground, their ability to predict future performance was much diminished, often to the point where their practical usefulness vanished altogether. This problem already emerged in the first major attempt at employing intelligence tests in the service of a noneducational institution, the U.S. Army in World War I. Most of the psychologists involved appear to have been convinced of the potential applicability of intelligence tests to military selection problems. However, although they were given considerable leeway and succeeded in testing well over a million men, the army does not seem to have found the results of this exercise particularly useful.¹ The military admin-

istrators were apparently more impressed by the contributions of a second group of psychologists who were prepared to tackle selection problems by means of an evaluation of nonintellectual qualities like loyalty, stability, vigor, and regard for authority. This second group worked under the direction of Walter Dill Scott, the only psychologist to be awarded a military decoration for his professional services to the army.²

Scott's academic base was in a business school where he had been addressing himself for some time to the selection problems faced by private employers of white collar workers. In particular, he had developed techniques for the selection of effective salesmen, and he recognized the potential applicability of these techniques in other institutional contexts – for instance, when looking for leadership qualities in the selection of officer candidates. In such practical contexts the ability to solve quasi-scholastic problems with unambiguously right or wrong answers obviously counted for little. What did count were personal qualities of a generally nonintellectual kind. The problem was to find a way of attaching numerical values to such qualities, so that individuals could be quantitatively compared with one another for the purpose of making the appropriate selection decisions. Scott's solution was to analyze the task requirements into a number of components and then to relate these components to designated personal qualities. Thus, a salesman's effectiveness was thought to depend on the components of "appearance and manner" and of "conversational effectiveness," while his value to the firm depended on "character," among other components. Any candidate could then be given a numerical rating on each of these components by comparing him to a standard group known to the interviewer. In making such assessments the rater was explicitly asked to take into account specific personal qualities such as cheerfulness and self-confidence in rating "appearance and manner," and honesty and ambition in rating "character." Much the same approach was used in officer selection.

Here then was a first approach to the quantification of personality. The possibility of quantification arose out of the fact that certain socially defined tasks could be carried out with different degrees of success by different individuals. As it was believed that these differences in task accomplishment depended on specific personal qualities, the quantitative prediction of degree of success in the task was automatically linked to an assessment of these personal qualities. At first this assessment remained embedded in a specific practical context. But the implicit model of human personality with which practical psychologists like Scott operated had obvious attractions for psychologists who were interested in developing a natural science of the universal characteristics of human individuals. In the implicit model, which underlay the rating practices of personnel selection, the individual was regarded as a collection of discrete, stable, and general qualities. These qualities were thought of as being identical in kind from one individual to

another, varying only in degree. Moreover, they were qualities that were manifest in assessment situations as well as in criterion situations for which prediction was desired. It was not long before the potentialities of this model were recognized and exploited.

During the 1920s it became more and more apparent that the early hopes for the practical efficacy of intelligence tests would not be fulfilled. Within the school system, their major area of application, these tests had proved capable of meeting administrative needs only up to a point. They did show some correlation with academic performance but not impressively so. The prediction of academic performance from intelligence-test results remained highly approximate, and this gave rise to a search for ways of closing the gap between predictive ambitions and the reality. A consensus quickly developed that intelligence was only one of the determinants of real-life performance, and that the other determinants would have to be looked for under the rubric of "character" or "personality." As a writer in the journal *Educational Administration and Supervision* put it: "It is quite probable that we have gone as far as we can go in psychology in predicting future success on the basis of things intellectual. The next development in this field must come through experimental study of character and personality traits. That character, personality, attitude, or whatever we may choose to call it, plays an important part in success cannot be doubted."³

This was not an isolated opinion. The literature of the period is full of similar suggestions, and in a number of cases these suggestions are immediately translated into practice.⁴ What is noteworthy about the expert opinion of the time is that the limited success of mental testing leads neither to a questioning of the administrative goals of testing nor to a questioning of its fundamental methodology. It is taken for granted that the goal of mental testing is the prediction of individual success in terms of administratively defined criteria. Intelligence tests had brought the achievement of this goal somewhat nearer. If they fell short of complete success, the fault was not likely to lie in any fundamental inappropriateness of the method; it was suggested, rather, that the domain of application of the method had not been sufficiently extensive. What was measured by intelligence tests, it now seemed, was not really a global mental power, or overall adaptive prowess, as the eugenicists among the testers had wanted to believe, but a more circumscribed kind of potential of a more specifically intellectual character.⁵ For more effective practical prediction the measurement of intelligence had to be complemented by the measurement of nonintellectual characteristics, which intelligence tests did not tap.

During this period the technology of intelligence testing was a source of pride to many American psychologists. It had been crucial in transforming the discipline from an ivory-tower pursuit to a significant form of social practice. Small wonder that it served as a model of technical sophistication when the problem of measuring nonintellectual features began to be faced

on a large scale. There had been earlier attempts at developing tests in this area, the association test and Downey's will-temperament test in particular. But these were now eclipsed by other instruments better adapted to the requirements of what was beginning to be called "personality measurement."⁶ The new instruments copied the features that had made group intelligence testing such an economical proposition. They were paper-and-pencil tests of simple format that could be readily administered to large groups of subjects and scored quickly and without any need for thought. Personality rating scales and inventories began to proliferate.

Constructing "personality" as an object of research

Two features of these instruments stand out: their reliance on an additive model of the human person and their identification of conventional verbal description with psychological reality. Such instruments consisted of a verbal label or title, like "ascendance" or "introversion," and a numerical structure implying that the quality referred to by the label existed in some measurable amount. The units for the operation of measurement were supplied either by the arbitrary subdivisions on a rating scale, or by the verbal items constituting a personality inventory. In either case, the psychological reality that was being constructed here involved the positing of features that were independently definable and isolable and that retained their identity across situations and across persons. Thus, the "introversion" in terms of which the behavior of individual *A* in situation *X* was described was assumed to be entirely comparable, not only with the "introversion" ascribed to the behavior of individual *A* in situation *Y*, but also with the "introversion" attributed to individual *B* in situation *Y*. Any difference in *B*'s "introversion" in situation *Y* and *A*'s "introversion" in situation *X* was purely quantitative. Qualitative variation of features had been extracted both from the description of individuals and from interindividual comparison and had been relegated to the abstract level of trait descriptions.⁷ One abstract trait differed qualitatively from other abstract traits, but individuals were limited to possessing larger or smaller quantities of identical features. These quantities were arrived at empirically by additive composition of items and comparison of the individual "raw scores" so generated.

It is instructive to compare this procedure with that which had been so successfully employed in the construction of measures of intellectual capacity. In that case the effectiveness of individuals had been gauged in task situations to which an unambiguous performance criterion could be applied. An answer was either right or wrong, and a larger number of right answers could be held to reflect a greater quantity of some ability. The use of task performance for the construction of scales of ability depended on the elimination of ambiguity. That is why only the final answer to a

question, or "intellectual yield," could be considered, and differences in the way that answer was arrived at had to be ignored.

In the construction of instruments for the measurement of ability, the elimination of ambiguity was thus achieved by restricting permissible tasks to those with unambiguously right or wrong answers and by ignoring the actual intellectual processes that produced a particular result. In constructing instruments for personality measurement, an analogous elimination of ambiguity had to be performed. This depended on two crucial operations, which bore some resemblance to those that had been employed in the construction of devices for the measurement of ability. The place of tasks with unambiguously right or wrong answers was taken by verbally labeled categories that retained an absolutely identical meaning irrespective of personal or situational context. This made it possible to carry out unambiguous attributions of quantities of the same characteristic across individuals and across situations in the manner already discussed.

The second potential source of ambiguity in personality assessment had its origin in the subjective processes that led up to the final rating. The meaning of a particular rating will depend on the connotations that the verbal trait label (or the key words in a questionnaire item) have acquired for the rater. It will also depend on the rater's sensitivity to the nuances of other people's conduct, on the rater's implicit psychological theories, on his or her preference for certain kinds of judgment, and on a host of other subjective factors. The new technique of personality assessment had a simple way around these sources of ambiguity by stipulating at the outset that the results of personality ratings were to be interpreted as reflecting attributes of the target person rather than attributes of the rater.⁸ Even in self-ratings, when target and rater were the same person, the results of the exercise were held to reflect on that person as the object and not as the subject of this self-reflective action.

The arbitrary element in this construal becomes quite evident when we compare the meaning attributed to the results of intelligence tests with that attributed to the results of personality ratings. In both cases we have the results of a task performance that are a joint function of the task and of the person engaged in it. In the case of personality ratings the task is to reduce the complex input received from the target person to a series of marks on simple scales. In principle, the outcome of such a task situation could be regarded as a reflection of some attribute of the rater or some attribute of the task. For instance, one could interpret individual differences in rating the same target(s) as a measure of the raters' sensitivity in applying particular judgment categories. But personality-rating tasks were typically not used to make inferences about the psychology of judgment. During the early period of personality psychology, and to a considerable extent thereafter, it was simply assumed that personality ratings were an unproblematic product of attributes of the task, not attributes of the rater.

In particular, such ratings were held to be a direct reflection of that part of the task that was constituted by the input received from the target person.

In the case of ability tests, any particular outcome can also be regarded as depending on both the person tested and the tasks. Just as persons can be ranked on the attribute of ability, tasks can be ranked on the attribute of difficulty. Does an individual fail at a particular task because the task is too difficult or because the individual lacks ability? The preferred explanation depended on prior theoretical commitments, like the belief in a fixed and inherited "general ability," and on the social interests behind those commitments.

Both intelligence testing and personality rating relied on problem-solving situations for their basic data. But by an act of constructive preselection the object of investigation was determined as being entirely different in the two cases. In the one case, performances in the problem-solving situation were held to reflect some inherent property of the problem solver (i.e., intelligence); in the other case, performances were taken to reflect inherent properties of the task (i.e., personality characteristics of the target person). The crucial point here is that the fundamental psychological meaning and reference of the empirical data were constituted by an interpretive construction that was not derived from those data but preceded their collection.

With a Galtonian paradigm of research practice, the arbitrary nature of the interpretative framework was typically disguised by operations of selection that limited the available empirical material to data appropriate to the preselected interpretive pole. Such data consisted of variances. If one wanted an empirical construction that lent itself to an interpretation in terms of differences in individual ability, one sampled across individual problem solvers and worked with interindividual variances on the same set of tasks. But if the task was one of personality rating, one produced sets of variances between the rated individuals rather than the raters. In either case the unwanted interpretation would become empirically invisible because there would be no corresponding variance to be interpreted. Of course, investigators were aware that in any particular case the outcome of the performance depended both on the performer and on the task object. Their split investigative practice made sense as long as one quietly assumed an additive relationship between these aspects, so that the one could be studied independently of the other. For that assumption, however, there was no warrant other than the investigative practices themselves.

In the course of time differences among raters were given some recognition in the form of interrater reliabilities. Once again, substantive problems were sidestepped by replacing them with a set of interindividual variances. Had these substantive problems been pursued, one crucial reason for differences among raters would have been traced to the fundamental dependence of the method on ambiguous natural language terms. This was

the case, both in the use of global trait categories, like "ascendancy-submission," and in the interpretation of specific items in an inventory, all of which relied on the raters' natural language competence. Personality ratings could very easily be recast as tests of the raters' sensitivity and competence in applying certain categories of their language. But of course, the ratings were supposed to be a direct reflection of the target personality, not a test of the raters' competence as members of a particular language community. It was as if intelligence-test results had been held to provide only a measure of some objective property of the tasks and had never been related to the ability of those being tested.

Although personality ratings and inventories were essentially an exercise in the application of certain verbal categories, they were presented as somehow analogous to natural scientific measurement. A particular set of natural language terms could therefore be made to take on the guise of categories of nature. The question of how terms like "ascendancy" or "dependence" functioned in the language games characterizing certain social relationships was not the kind of question that motivated these investigative practices. Instead, "ascendancy," "dependence," and the rest, were treated as unambiguous properties of the natural world that were to be investigated much as a nineteenth-century physicist might have investigated electrical resistance. What this amounted to was a masquerade in which categories generated by a very specific social order were held to represent an ahistorical natural order.

The categories with which the new psychology of personality operated were always highly dependent on a particular social context. This was quite evident when its characteristic investigative procedures first appeared in the form of personal ratings in the practice of personnel selection. Obviously, the categories on which prospective salesmen or prospective officers were rated depended on what was considered to be relevant to the efficient performance of their jobs. The social context in which the rating procedure was applied automatically provided criteria for the selection of a few personal qualities out of the potentially unmanageable multiplicity of such qualities. However, when personality psychology began to be pursued independently of such specific practical settings, it did not mean that it now selected its categories independently of any social context. No psychological theory functioned as a source of criteria for deciding which, out of a virtually unlimited variety of possible trait concepts, were to be regarded as particularly important. In the absence of any theoretical model that might distinguish among traits in terms of their *psychological* significance, the choice of the personality categories that formed the object of investigative practice was ultimately determined by their apparent practical usefulness or by their "intuitive" interest, the latter entirely governed by cultural factors that were subject to the usual limitations of time and place.⁹

One consequence of this was an extraordinary fluctuation in the personality categories considered worthy of psychological investigation at dif-

ferent times. Thus, if one examines all the articles published in a key journal, like the *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology*, over a period of several decades, one finds considerable variation in the relative frequency with which various terms referring to personality traits are used.¹⁰ Comparing the period 1920–1935 with the period 1940–1955, there is a sharp decline in the popularity of the early favorites: The personality category of “extraversion,” for example, drops from being used in 39 percent of all articles employing trait terms to only 6 percent in the later period, and “ascendancy” drops from 21 to 3 percent. On the other hand, the category of “emotionality” rises from 11 to 22 percent. Some categories disappear in the course of time, others appear and flourish for a while, only to be eclipsed in their turn. There appear to be no grounds intrinsic to the subject matter for this constantly shifting empirical basis of trait psychology. It is much more likely that these changes represent the coming and going of research fads, but in this case the fads are directly related to events in the social environment of the discipline.

Thus, the strong attention paid to the polar categories of “ascendancy” and “submission” during the early period of American personality research appears to reflect its practical roots in personnel and officer selection. In both those contexts the goal was to pick individuals who could be relied upon by their superiors to take charge of situations and impose their intentions on others. This was conceptualized in terms of stable intraindividual qualities that varied in amount from one person to another. Psychologists not only contributed a technique that could be claimed to measure this amount but also supplied a reified category that translated the general social requirement into psychological terms. Numerous instances of the socially desired outcome were aggregated to contribute to an abstract quality of “ascendancy,” or its opposite, that was now thought to reside not in interpersonal situations but within strictly autonomous individuals. This made it possible to conceive of a new field of research that would take such general intraindividual qualities as its object and that would not be directly tied to specific practical requirements.

The construction of personality traits as objects of investigation led to the emergence of a brand new area of psychological research. In the American Psychological Association Yearbook for 1918, not a single psychologist listed “personality” as a research interest, but by 1937, 7 percent did so.¹¹ The earliest attempts to review the new research area already show that it was dominated by the trait concept.¹² It was the investigative practice of trait measurement that was to translate certain culturally embedded concerns into something that could sail under the flag of science.

The uses of personality research

Personality research would hardly have achieved the kind of position it did without an ideological component that gave a more general significance to

its rather modest technical roots in personnel selection. During the founding period of American personality research, this component was supplied by a powerful and well-funded social movement, the mental hygiene movement. Growing out of seeds sown in the period before World War I, this movement achieved a pervasive influence during the 1920s and 1930s.¹³ At first confined to more specifically psychiatric concerns, it quickly spread to the educational system and to the area of child care in general. It affected many of the institutions with which psychologists had practical links and created new ones that psychologists were often able to exploit for the advancement of their own professional project. Favored by generous grants from private foundations,¹⁴ the mental hygiene movement was based on the twin beliefs that the causes of social and interpersonal problems were to be located in the maladjustment of individuals and that the origins of such maladjustment lay in the histories of individuals – that is, in childhood. Interpreting social life in terms of metaphors of health and illness, the mental hygiene movement projected hopes of a better future that was to emerge, not through the conflict of collective social interests, but through the “treatment” of individual maladjustment by the appropriate agencies of social control.¹⁵ If such treatment was usually ineffectual, this could only be because it lacked a scientific basis, because not enough was known of the causes of individual maladjustment. A better knowledge base was needed, and psychologists were just the people to produce it.

Two areas of psychological research were primarily affected by the mental hygiene movement, child development and personality research. The effect on the former was quite direct, taking the form of massive grants of money.¹⁶ In the case of the very new area of personality research the effect was more subtle but nevertheless beneficial in the long run. The concept of “personality” played a central role in the ideology of mental hygiene. “Personality” was posited as the object, which was to be the focus of a variety of energetically pursued programs of intervention in the lives of individuals.¹⁷ In practice, these programs were quite diverse but they were thought of as converging on a common object, namely “personality.”¹⁸ Psychiatrists, social workers, and educationists occupied the key positions in the mental hygiene movement because of their activist involvement in practical programs, but psychologists found their own niche by functioning as a source of expert knowledge about the common object of these programs. Their claims were based on their supposed ability to marshal the techniques of science in the service of the common goal. In practice this generally came down to the construction and application of scales that would subject “personality” to the rigors of measurement and so convert it from merely an object of social intervention into an object of science. Their transformation of a presupposition for common practical action into a reified natural object was no mean service.

For the discipline of psychology the new field provided an opportunity for achieving another felicitous synthesis of the demands of practical relevance and scientific appearances. But the costs of this achievement were considerable. What was given up was an earlier tradition of detailed study of individuals and of specific life events. When the *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology* was taken over by the American Psychological Association in 1925, there was an immediate and dramatic change in the investigative practices on which published articles were based. Whereas in 1924 80 percent of the empirical papers published were based on the study of individual cases, that proportion dropped to 25 percent in the following year. Their place was taken by statistical studies based on group data, as was required by the prevailing Galtonian paradigm for psychological measurement.¹⁹ Individuals were to be known only through their standing in a group. The display of numbers was able to pass for science, and the information produced by these means had its practical uses in the context of mass programs of therapeutic intervention. But the kind of knowledge of individuals that was generated in this way always remained a knowledge of strangers.²⁰ "Personality" as a constructed object of these investigations never had anything in common with traditional concepts of the human person as a social agent.

Character as an investigative object in Germany

In 1933 the British psychologist, P. E. Vernon, published an even-handed critical comment on the extreme contrast between American and German approaches to the study of personality.²¹ American investigators, in their almost exclusive reliance on tests, seemed to have substituted technology for science. Conventional European opinion, Vernon thought, would probably dismiss the testing approach as arising from the desire to exploit and improve people, rather than to understand people. In Europe, the study of personality was particularly well developed in Germany, and there the qualitative approach ruled supreme. From this point of view it made no sense to aggregate trait values from different individuals because the quality of a trait was part of the whole personality and therefore would vary from one person to another. However, when it came to validating their personality descriptions, the methods of the German investigators were "unashamedly subjective."

These methods, which Vernon dismissed in two words, actually represent a rather interesting chapter in the history of psychology's investigative practices precisely because the contrast between them and the dominant practices is so extreme. Their "subjectivity" was anything but naive, and they were taken very seriously by many European psychologists at the time. How was such an extreme divergence possible within the same discipline? To answer this question, we will have to begin by describing the

basis of these practices and then take up the question of the social conditions under which they flourished.

Despite their diversity, all the practices we have considered so far have in common a certain kind of relationship between the investigator and the object of his or her investigation. This relationship could be described as distanced and as intellectual. A major point of studying people in special situations like experiments or tests was to preclude the development of a normal human interaction among subjects and investigators. The latter, in particular, were to treat their human reactions to their experimental subjects as scientifically irrelevant and were to regard them simply as objects of intellectual interest. Any reaction that an investigator had to the subject as a human person was definitely not part of the official definition of an investigative situation. The investigator figured in this definition purely as a machine for analyzing data and drawing logical conclusions.

Even before the end of the nineteenth century there were those who felt that this feature of the new psychology precluded its application to the study of personality. By far the most influential voice was that of Wilhelm Dilthey, who sharply expressed the general distaste that practitioners of the *Geisteswissenschaften* felt toward an experimental psychology. Such a psychology, according to Dilthey,²² would be of no use to the historian, for example, who had to make sense of the actions of individual personalities under specific historical circumstances. The results of experimental psychology would be irrelevant in this context because, at best, they might lead to an "explanation" of human behavior that was analogous to a physicist's explanation for the behavior of an inanimate object. Experimental, or "explanatory," psychology was only able to achieve its results by treating human individuals as objects – that is, by pretending that our way of knowing other people was not fundamentally different from our way of knowing planets or plants. But everybody knows that that is not true in everyday life. We accept other people as having experiences, feelings, and desires, just like ourselves, and this means that their actions are directly meaningful to us. Dilthey's proposal was that this everyday experience be accepted as the basis for a different kind of psychology. He called it *Verstehend* (understanding) because its aim was not the production of covering law-type explanations but the elucidation of the psychological meaning that could be directly sensed in a person's actions.

Dilthey's proposal went rather deep. It implied a departure from the entire Enlightenment tradition of knowledge production, according to which only rationally processed sensory knowledge could provide the basis for a science. For Dilthey, however, the basis of all knowledge was not any kind of neutral, gutless, elementary sense experience, but something for which he and his many followers used the term *Erlebnis*. The closest English equivalent is "experience," but more in the sense of "living through" or "witnessing" than in the sense of dispassionate observation.

In an interpersonal context this manifested itself as a direct intuiting of the pattern of meaning running through another individual's actions or the products of those actions.

Other German writers developed these ideas in a direction that led to the emergence of a new kind of psychological practice. Theodor Lipps, who was much more involved in psychology than Dilthey, gave a more concrete turn to the latter's rather general suggestions. Lipps was of the opinion that we have a general tendency to reproduce, at least in imagination, the affectively toned actions and gestures of others.²³ Because the other person's meaning is expressed in these gestures, we are able to experience (*erleben*) that meaning ourselves by reproducing the gestures.²⁴ This is the basis for a direct psychological understanding of other people.²⁵

Ludwig Klages gave a similar, though less specific, account of the way in which we understand other people. In his case, however, this general orientation is very much linked to a specific, practical methodology, namely, the interpretation of handwriting.²⁶ Klages's approach to graphology is definitely to be referred to as an *interpretation* rather than an *analysis* of handwriting. Unlike his predecessors in this area,²⁷ he did not attempt to correlate specific features of handwriting with specific personality traits. Such a procedure would have introduced nothing new into the investigative practices of psychology. Klages, however, advocated a procedure whereby the psychological significance of each handwriting feature would have to be determined in the light of the overall impression that the handwriting made on the graphologist. The latter was supposed to be able to reproduce in herself, and thus to know directly, the overall quality of experience that the handwriting expressed, whether it was rich, deep, and warm or restricted, flat, and cold.

It is obvious that a different kind of psychological practice has been introduced here. The separation between the investigator as subject and the external object of investigation has become fuzzy. The investigator's affective reactions have become an important component of investigative practice, and the personal characteristics of the investigator have become crucial. Other methods were based on objectively specifiable procedures that could be more or less automatized, but in the new graphology the intuitive talent of the individual graphologist constituted a basic and irreplaceable factor.

Although graphology was the area in which the new approach to psychological research was worked out most systematically, it was not the only area that provided a stage for a practice based on the principle of *erleben*. Other techniques, which had for the most part had a long and decidedly checkered history,²⁸ were recruited in the service of the new approach. These techniques were grouped together under the heading of "the psychology of expression," and they included the interpretation of facial expression, gesture, posture and movement, voice quality, and even body

build and physiognomic appearance. All these were features that were open to psychological interpretation if one thought of them as directly expressing the quality of the individual's affective life and personality. These direct expressions could then be picked up and characterized by talented and experienced interpreters.

The skill of the individual interpreter might be considered crucial, but this did not mean that he or she was given a free hand with regard to the terms in which the interpretation was to be expressed. In principle, the interpretation might have been framed in terms of episodic psychological events or situational factors. For instance, facial expression might have been of interest because of its relation to fluctuating affective experiences, or posture might have been studied in relation to the social psychological situation.²⁹ But these were not the knowledge objects that these German students of personality favored. The object that they sought to construct by means of their expressive methods was categorized as "character,"³⁰ a concept that represented an objectification and a synthesis of a number of rules for the explanation of human conduct.

Among the more important of these rules were the following: Human conduct was not to be explained as situationally determined but as issuing from sources entirely within the individual; these inner sources were not to be regarded as changing and developing but were to be thought of as static, permanent and unchangeable structures; the inner sources of human conduct were not to be described in a neutral, quasi-naturalistic language because they had an inherent value, positive or negative, and were therefore to be referred to in ways that expressed this value; the inner sources of human conduct were always to be thought of as constituting a unity, not as an aggregate of components.

The very term "psychology of expression" or "expressive methods" already presupposed a particular model of psychological explanation, incorporating at least some of the above rules. By defining certain features of human behavior as "expressive," these psychologists could consider themselves to be studying not the behavior as such but the presupposed underlying characterological reality. Moreover, the philosophy of *erleben* gave them reason to believe that they were able to have direct access to this reality. The norm of separating factual statements from theoretical statements, characteristic of natural science, would not apply; instead, empirical and theoretical statements were fused in an analogical synthesis. A specimen of handwriting, for instance, might be described as cramped or expansive, but this would simultaneously function as the description of an underlying personal reality. There could be no question, with such a procedure, of "validating" one's theoretical claims – they were indissolubly fused with relatively empirical statements.

One might well be inclined to wonder what kind of knowledge interest such a form of psychological practice could conceivably serve. For some

of the early practitioners the explanation seems to lie in the persisting dependence of German psychology on German philosophy, already referred to in chapter 8. German psychologists were not only under pressure to legitimize their contribution in the eyes of philosophers in institutionalized positions of authority; they often owed their academic appointments to their judged competence in the field of philosophy.³¹ When the irrationalist wing within German philosophy gained in influence, as it did in the early part of the twentieth century,³² this could hardly fail to have its effects on at least some German psychologists.

But such factors would hardly have sufficed to transform a romantic fantasy into a historically significant form of psychological practice. The crucial impetus for this development came from outside the academic world. After World War I there was an, albeit limited, market in German industry for procedures that claimed to assess not only individuals' technical skills but also their personal qualities.³³ Graphology, in particular, was able to meet the requirements of this market. But this hardly accounts for the general efflorescence of expressive methods, especially in the 1930s. To discover the crucial factor in this development, we must look in another direction. It is a direction from which American psychology had previously received a crucial boost, namely the military.

Whereas American psychologists were able to turn their army work during World War I to great advantage for the prestige of their discipline, this had not been the case in Germany. There, the psychological contribution during World War I had been limited to the selection of a few specialists like radio telegraphists and artillery spotters. The big chance for the collaboration of German psychology with the German military began a decade later, during the Weimar Republic. Under the Treaty of Versailles, the German officer corps had been greatly reduced in size, which had the effect of making the military authorities determined to make up in quality at least part of what they lacked in quantity. In the immediate postwar period the persistence of the old military caste system and people's recent memories of the horrors of war prevented any innovations. But a decade later a military career was once again attractive to many. There was now a large pool of applicants for a very small number of officer vacancies.³⁴ At the same time, political criticism of the traditional recruitment of officers from a privileged social stratum began to become quite vocal. The introduction of personality tests for all officer candidates offered a solution to both problems. It established a basis for officer selection that could replace family status, and it provided an apparently nonarbitrary procedure for selecting the most promising candidates from a large pool of applicants.³⁵

German psychologists had proved their military usefulness at least to the extent that after the end of World War I a small psychological testing service was carried over into the army of the Weimar Republic. That service

was concerned with skill testing for special occupations. But when its head, J. B. Rieffert, seized the opportunity presented by the altered situation in 1927 to propose a reorientation to personality testing for officer candidates, his proposal was accepted with alacrity.

To appeal to their superiors, German military psychologists had to use the right language. "Character" had long been an attribute highly valued within the tradition of Prussian-German militarism. It was considered to be crucial for a successful military career. So it was "character" that psychologists had to claim to be able to assess if they were to be of use in the selection of future officers. But how were they to make good on this claim? American pencil-and-paper tests would have produced nothing but contempt and derision among their military superiors who were the survivors of total war. To be at all credible the psychological testing situations had to simulate at least some features of real military life. Accordingly, situations were invented in which the candidates were put under considerable stress, having to carry out difficult tasks while under observation, and having to function as group leaders in competitive situations.³⁶ Psychologists did not simply function as uninvolved observers in these situations but intervened to challenge the candidates and generally to make the tasks more demanding and stressful.³⁷

These were situations then in which officer candidates might be expected to show their qualities of "character." But these qualities still had to be assessed. For this purpose the German army psychologists fell back on the only practical proposal available to them, that of the psychology of expression. Their observation of officer candidates concentrated on expressive behavior, like voice quality (Rieffert's special field), facial expression, posture, and movement. Such observations were regarded as providing direct access to characterological qualities in the manner previously discussed.

Thanks to its military development, an approach that otherwise might have remained a philosophical curiosity was transformed into a significant form of psychological investigative practice: The procedures worked out in the military context not only served purely practical purposes; they also provided the basis for German academic personality psychology during the period leading up to World War II and for many years after its end.³⁸

This development was greatly accelerated by the policies of the Nazi government that assumed power at the beginning of 1933. Its frantic expansion of the German armed forces led to the creation of a large number of vacancies in the officer corps and a relatively huge increase in the number of army psychologists required for the task of officer selection.³⁹ The German armed forces became by far the largest employer of psychologists in the country. By 1941 the discipline achieved what had always been so difficult in Germany – namely, its official recognition as an autonomous profession through the institution of a state examination in psychology. The selection of officers for the Nazi army had finally provided the discipline

with an opportunity to prove its usefulness to the centers of social power.⁴⁰ It should be noted, however, that the actual practices on which this demonstration was based were a direct continuation of the pattern that had been established during the Weimar Republic. The Nazi influence on German psychology reinforced certain already existing tendencies and put an end to others by forcing their representatives into exile.

This is not to say that there was any lack of congruence between the cultural values expressed in the psychologists' practices and those incorporated in the ruling ideology. In their day-to-day work, the German army psychologists had to make characterological attributions on the basis of the expressive behavior of the candidates that they observed. But these attributions required a network of characterological categories without which nothing could have been reported. Naturally, these categories had to be relevant to the practical purpose in view – the selection of men who were likely to carry out their tasks well in time of war. So it comes as no surprise to find that the category of “will” played a central role in these characterological systems. The way in which this category was interpreted depended strongly on the traditions of Prussian militarism.⁴¹ “Will” was supposed to express itself in such things as a taut and upright posture, and in a particular way of shouting commands.

Why there were different psychologies of personality

The key point is that psychologists had no way of talking about human personality that was not based on cultural preconceptions *and* on the interests of particular groups within that culture. American psychologists might rate on “ascendancy” and German psychologists might intuit qualities of “will,” but their dependence on local cultural definitions of their task was equally profound. This dependence was not only conceptual, it extended to the specific practical purposes that served as a point of departure for their work. Their construction of “personality” or “character” as an object of knowledge was strictly confined by the rather severe limitations of the social context in which their investigations originated.

Language was always the key to the problem. Practical psychologists had to operate with verbal categories that could be used in their communication with those who provided a real or potential market for the results of their work. But that meant that the interests and preconceptions of the consumers of psychological knowledge tended to be reflected in the verbal categories used by the psychologists.

However, psychologists also needed unambiguous categories that would permit effective communication among themselves. The two sets of requirements were not easily reconciled, for the everyday terms on which the lay public insisted were incorrigibly vague and ambiguous. The American psychologists were rather more successful in meeting the requirements

of a relatively unambiguous intradisciplinary language, whereas the German psychologists were perhaps more successful in appealing at least to the special section of the lay public that mattered to them. They were then left with the unresolved problem of developing a general and unambiguous language for intradisciplinary communication,⁴² while their American counterparts were struggling to relate their personality-test scores back to the real world. Neither group progressed beyond an essentially descriptive network of terms to develop anything that could legitimately be called a *theory* of personality, unless by theory one simply means a set of implicit presuppositions.

In terms of their investigative practice there were of course profound differences between German and American personality psychologists. The latter kept the person under investigation at arm's length, using him or her only as a source for the real object of investigation, which was a quantitative score. The Germans, on the other hand, interacted with their candidates quite intensely over a period of several days, taking anything but a neutral observer's role. They saw their main task as that of creating a particular human situation, not that of producing a quantitative result. The qualitative nature of their methods was perfectly adapted to their social task, which was the selection of an elite that would function as the perfect representative of certain culturally defined values.⁴³ Selection criteria for this operation were mainly derived from Prussian traditions about what characterized a good officer; it is astounding how primitive and halfhearted were the attempts at verifying what personal qualities, if any, actually made a difference in combat situations. The methods of the German army psychologists were methods designed to select individual models of a certain kind of human being.

This had no necessary connection with morale on the battlefield, which depended on a multitude of social and situational factors. Ironically, these military psychologists were far more effective in helping to build a peacetime army than in helping to win a war.⁴⁴ In the end they had to admit that they were unable to predict courageous conduct, a failure they attributed to the difficulty of assessing "will."⁴⁵ It did not occur to them that there never was any such thing, that their basic assumption of a fixed inner character that accounted for social conduct in many particular situations was mistaken.

Psychological selection can be based on two kinds of considerations. On the one hand, there is the question of whether a selected group performs discriminably better in a criterion situation than an unselected group. This essentially statistical question can be answered without the slightest insight into the reasons for any detected difference. The considerations here are purely *technical*. On the other hand, *ideological* considerations usually enter into the selection process as well. There are all kinds of culturally sanctioned preconceptions about who is likely to succeed in what situations.

Psychological selection often took these preconceptions for granted. But beyond that there is the purely ideological selection for which the history of German personality psychology provides the most striking examples. Certain individuals may be considered worthy of selection because they represent a valued or desirable human type. If this is the kind of selection one is interested in, one's methods of choice will be qualitative. Under these circumstances, the main social function of psychological procedures will be the affirmation of the particular cultural values that have been built into them.

Although there are clearly differences in degree, no psychological assessment can altogether escape the ideological component in selection. As long as psychological performance is summarized in categories to which verbal labels are attached, an evaluative component is unavoidable. Attaching these labels to "traits" rather than to aspects of "character structure" makes no essential difference to the nature of the problem.

Lost continent: Lewin's Berlin group

The Weimar period in German history was a period of unrelieved instability and intense social conflict. German society was divided into mutually antagonistic interest groups, few of which felt any loyalty to the weak state that had emerged from the defeat of World War I. During the latter part of the Weimar period these social conflicts developed into a more and more pronounced polarization of cultural and political life. Rather unsurprisingly, this polarization recurs on the level of psychological personality study. This was a part of psychological investigation that was intensely sensitive to prevailing cultural imperatives, all the more so as it was not based on any previously existing autonomous research tradition.

We have seen how the pattern of investigative practice based on the link between characterology and the psychology of expression was involved in the temporarily profitable alliance between a section of the German psychological community and reactionary militarism. But there were other sections of this community, including all its Jewish members, for whom such an alliance was out of the question. In this group more traditional patterns of investigative practice maintained themselves, with one exception.⁴⁶ That exception was located at the Psychological Institute of the University of Berlin, where a group of young investigators, centered around the person of Kurt Lewin, developed a distinctly innovative form of practice in the field of personality research. Although the common intellectual categories of this group were based on German psychology and philosophy, their social background was more often than not female, Jewish, and eastern European. This was a rather cosmopolitan group whose spontaneous sensitivity to and awareness of social psychological questions were obviously far greater than tends to be the case in more homogeneous and

more locally rooted groups. It is not surprising that their approach to the study of personality was marked by an intense sense of the embeddedness of the personality in social situations. This was a major source for the innovative elements in their investigative practice.

In the first place, the practice of this group represented a clean break with the static personality model implied in German characterology and the equally static American trait psychology. The behavior of persons in investigative situations was no longer seen as an expression of their character or as a manifestation of their personality traits, but as a part of the situation in which the person was embedded. The whole idea of a psychology of character or personality as such was inappropriate from this point of view, for the object of investigation here was not the isolated individual but the person-in-a-situation.

A different relationship between experimenters and subjects was a crucial condition for the practical constitution of this novel object of investigation. The production of abstract individuals as objects of research had been the common purpose of American trait psychology and German characterology. The former achieved this effect by reducing the interaction of investigators and subjects to a minimum and then pretending that the behavior of subjects was emitted in a social vacuum. The German representatives of expressive characterology achieved an analogous social reduction by a monadic model in which the subject's behavior was no more than an individual symptom that could only be understood as such by the investigator, but which had merely an accidental relationship to the investigative situation.

By contrast, the investigations of the Berlin group included the interaction between experimenters and subjects as part of the object of investigation from the beginning.⁴⁷ That interaction was not regarded simply as part of the technology required to evoke the response that would be the real object of investigation. Because the object of investigation for the Berlin group was not the isolated individual but the person-in-a-situation, the relationship of subjects and investigators, being part of the situation, was necessarily part of the object of investigation.

For example, in the famous study of anger by Tamara Dembo⁴⁸ the changing relationship between experimenter and subject in the course of the experiment is analyzed in some detail because it is a crucial part of the anger-producing situation in which the subject finds herself. Faced with a very difficult or insoluble problem, experimental subjects begin by asking for help, which is not forthcoming. They may then try to test the experimenter's authority, divert her attention, or show exaggerated submissiveness, until eventually an overt conflict situation becomes unavoidable. The personal affect of anger arises in this situation and obtains its meaning from it. Anger is a phenomenon that is situated in a social field formed by the power of the experimenter and the subject's efforts to come to terms

with it.⁴⁹ In this type of analysis the social practice of investigation for the first time becomes an object of research interest. However, unlike much later developments, in which the “social psychology of psychological experiments” is pursued as a separate topic, there is no division between the social and the technical aspects of experimentation. The investigative situation is recognized as intrinsically social, and in research on personality it must form part of the object of investigation.

From the perspective of the Berlin group it made no sense to try to limit the interaction of experimenters and subjects to a minimum, as had seemed desirable to investigators that sought to approximate the practices of natural science in their research. Because the objects of natural scientific research cannot “answer back” or give an intentional account of themselves, many psychological investigators had sought to approximate this state of affairs in their relations with their experimental subjects. For Kurt Lewin and his group, however, this was an absurd methodological precept for the science of psychology. Even before the emergence of the Berlin research program, Lewin had rejected the arguments for minimizing experimenter–subject interaction. Taking the then current method of “systematic experimental introspection” (see chapter 3) as his point of departure, he showed himself to be intensely aware of the crucial role of communication in the methodology of introspection.⁵⁰ He rejected the incorrigibility of subjective reports and defined the aim of such studies in terms of a *mutual understanding* among experimenters and subjects – not in terms of the isolated individual consciousness. From this point of view the experimenter had to make an active contribution to the dialogue that formed the basis of the experimental results. Along the same lines, the members of Lewin’s research group proceeded to emphasize the dangers in a “passive,” rigidly rule-following model of experimenter behavior.⁵¹

The novelty in the investigative practice of Lewin’s Berlin group lay in the fact that it departed fundamentally from the natural scientific model of experimentation and substituted for this a style of experimentation that attempted to do justice to the special problems of conducting empirical research on human persons.

One aspect of this turn toward a more specifically *psychological* kind of experimentation involved the rejection of the “arithmomorphic” division of human behavior that was discussed in chapter 9. There was to be no attempt to superimpose a unitizing schema on human action that would lead to countable identical elements, for the psychological significance of any action element would vary with the context:

One ought not to regard the single trial as an isolated formation that is only identical with preceding and succeeding trials of the same kind because that is what is required for purposes of statistical treatment. Rather, one ought to treat each trial essentially nonstatistically, as a

single concrete process in its full reality. One will have to take into account the particular position of each trial in the temporal series of trials and partly make the transition to constructing [*gestalten*] the experimental period as a unitary whole.⁵²

Human actions form structured wholes often extending over considerable periods of time, and any elementary component of such action sequences obtains its psychological meaning from the action structure in which it is embedded. Thus, psychological experimentation must be dedicated to the discovery of essentially qualitative relationships.

Just as the elementaristic deconstruction of human action is rejected in this type of investigative practice, so is the reduction of the environmental context to specific "stimuli." The environmental field within which a person acts forms a structured whole in which each element obtains its meaning from its relation to the entire structure.⁵³ An attempt at studying the investigative object person-in-a-situation cannot be based on establishing relationships between specific behavior elements and specific stimulus elements.

If the meaning of any stimulus or behavior element depends on its embeddedness in larger structures, it follows that the same action component can have an entirely different psychological significance, depending on the context. This means that measures of performance against external criteria, as favored by psychological research since the beginning of the century (see chapter 9), are at best useless and at worst misleading if one is trying to grasp the psychological significance of an action. Even in the acquisition of such an apparently straightforward skill as typing, the cumulation of successive performance measures distorts the psychological reality. For at the beginning of the process of skill acquisition, the action of typing is embedded in a psychological situation that is very different from the situation when the skill is better established, and this situation is different again from the one that exists for the fully trained typist.⁵⁴

It is clear that a form of investigative practice dedicated to understanding human behavior in its personal and social context cannot lead to results expressed in terms of relationships among independently defined variables. Does this mean that the aim of psychological research is to be limited to the description of specific situations? This was an alternative that Lewin rejected in the most emphatic manner. He did so because he was convinced that psychologically significant situations have a depth dimension that makes all surface description inadequate. Lewin had served his apprenticeship as a psychological investigator within a research program dedicated to the experimental study of volition. That program had strong ties to the methodology of "systematic experimental introspection" (see chapter 3), a term that was in fact coined by the main representative of the program, Narziss Ach.⁵⁵ Accordingly, it was largely devoted to investigating the

subjective *experience* of volition, although Ach also attempted to measure the strength of will. However, Lewin found that there was no relationship at all between these two aspects of volition. A less intensely felt intention could have a much greater effect than a more intensely felt one and vice versa.⁵⁶ A merely phenomenal description of psychological events was therefore inadequate.⁵⁷

Working out the full implications of this insight depended on Lewin's very intensive studies in the philosophy of science.⁵⁸ These convinced him of the necessity of making a general distinction between the surface pattern of events and an underlying causally effective reality. He referred to this as the distinction between "phenotype" and "genotype," and it became the indispensable centerpiece of his approach.⁵⁹ Studying psychological events in context meant more than taking into account the temporal dimension of action structures. It meant penetrating beyond the apparent meaning of an action to an underlying context that was causally effective. For example, two actions might be indistinguishable on the surface, but genotypically the one might represent the carrying out of an order and the other the carrying out of a voluntary intention. The aim of psychological investigation was the exploration of the genotypical context of human actions. "Personality" or "character" as reified static entities are replaced by types of psychological context as the real objects of psychological investigation.

"Types of psychological context," however, cannot be discovered inductively.⁶⁰ Genotypical contexts are decidedly not empirical generalizations from a number of similar cases. They are theoretical constructions whose empirical verification could in principle be achieved by the demonstration of a single appropriate case. Lewin makes a distinction between "being-thus" (*Sosein*) and "being-there" (*Dasein*).⁶¹ The first concept refers to the nature of a type, the second to the realization of a type in empirical reality. Rationally, the exploration of the former should precede the establishment of the latter, for if one started with the collection of empirical facts, one would merely be aggregating instances on the basis of superficial resemblance. Lewin strongly criticized the widespread psychological research practice of forming statistical aggregates on the basis of "historical-geographic" criteria,⁶² such as membership of specific social groups (see chapter 5). Such criteria were not psychological criteria at all, and their use to form statistical aggregates could only result in the formation of psychologically heterogeneous entities from which no psychological insights could be expected.

For the Berlin group the aim of psychological research was not the search for statistical regularities defining the relationship among isolated variables. Testing the statistical null hypothesis would constitute the polar opposite to their style of research practice. The lawfulness of psychological processes was assumed a priori; it was not something to be established by a statistical

test. But the conception of lawfulness involved here had nothing to do with the statistical frequency of association among specific empirical measures. Rather, it involved the belief in the existence of specific genotypically effective “process types” (*Geschehenstypus*).⁶³ These were qualitatively distinct and temporally extended patterns of events that were characteristic of specific human situations. The concrete research practice of the Berlin group was dedicated to the experimental simulation of such situations – for example, anger-producing situations or situations of psychological satiation.⁶⁴ These investigations were “experimental,” not only in the sense that they represented an artificial re-creation of common human situations, but also because they included planned variations in these situations for the purpose of exploring their genotypical structure.

The Berlin group fell victim to the full destructive force of Nazism. Its members were scattered and had no chance of maintaining the extraordinary momentum that the group had developed during the relatively brief period of its existence. Lewin himself emigrated to America, where he faced several years of marginalization by the psychological establishment. His ability to address socially interesting topics brought him considerable fame during the World War II period, but he died early in 1946. As far as the distinctive aspects of his form of investigative practice are concerned, his influence on American personality research was slight. Most of the early methodologically important papers remained untranslated, and those of his students who showed any inclination to incorporate his methodological precepts into their own work were excluded from the experimental mainstream of American psychology.⁶⁵ In addition, Lewin’s own preoccupation with problems of formalization during his post-Berlin period tended to divert attention from the most innovative aspects of his contribution to its more sterile aspects. From a methodological point of view, the “Lewin legacy” remained something of a buried treasure.

11

The social construction of psychological knowledge

The preceding analysis of the historical development of investigative practices in psychology is obviously based on a certain model of the investigative process. Although various aspects of this model have emerged in previous chapters, some of the basic features of the model still need to be made explicit. The first part of this chapter is devoted to this task. In the remainder of the chapter I briefly address some general questions pertaining to the status of psychological knowledge that arise out of the kind of analysis presented here. These questions all revolve around the issue of how the social construction of psychological knowledge affects the reach of the knowledge product. Although knowledge claims are generated in specific sociohistorical situations, it does not follow that they have no significance or validity beyond those situations. There are two possibilities here. First, psychological knowledge may be generalizable to situations other than those in which it was generated. This is the question of applicability. More fundamentally, however, there is the possibility that psychological knowledge claims may be able to tap a level of “psychological reality” that is independent of the special conditions under which it is investigated. The second and third sections of this chapter discuss these possibilities.

The political economy of knowledge production

Investigative practices are part of a productive work process. Their employment results in the generation of valued products, though of course these are not primarily material but symbolic products – namely, scientific knowledge claims. This same employment necessarily involves people who put these practices to work and also some kind of raw material that is productively transformed into the valued knowledge product. Producers of scientific knowledge never work as independent individuals but are